

Orangutan

Orangutans are the largest tree-living great ape. They use their long arms and huge hands to move easily through the tropical forests of Indonesia. Their life cycle is slow compared to most other mammals. Mothers give birth once every six to eight years and have just four or five babies in their lifetime.

Orangutans are more likely to breed when there is plenty of fruit growing on the trees.

Pairing up

Orangutans pair up only briefly to mate. Females are attracted to the long calls of large, dominant males, which can be heard about half a mile (1 km) away.

Mature males have cheek pads called flanges—these are an added attraction to females.

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Mother and baby

Females are pregnant for around eight months. Once the baby is born, the mother bends tree branches to make a sleeping platform and builds a nest from leaves and sticks. The baby nurses for about two years and will stay with its mother for up to nine years.

Each night, the mother climbs up to her nest, with her baby clinging on tightly.

